

In mid-September, however, the cabal overplayed its hand. They first tried to bribe the president's private secretary, and when that failed Corbin wrote a letter to Grant, checking to see if the president planned to continue with his strategy of not selling gold through the month. Upon getting the letter on September 19, Grant became suspicious of foul play and instructed his wife to write to Mrs. Corbin to convince her husband to steer clear of the ruse.³⁵

Unsurprisingly, Mr. Corbin was dismayed that Grant was catching on to the plot. Upon learning of the situation, Gould knew he could no longer depend on Grant to hold the nation's gold. Under the cover of Fisk's continued buying, Gould started unloading the gold he had acquired.

While the Gold Exchange had been rising continuously throughout September, on September 24, 1869, it peaked and would go down as "Jay Gould's Black Friday." Gould had employed a dozen brokers to continue quietly selling his gold, while his partner Fisk pushed the gold market to \$160, a 20 percent rise from its bottom earlier in the year. Shortly thereafter, Butterfield's broker started selling gold, which alerted those at the exchange that the federal government was likely on its way to a sale. Sure enough, an hour after gold hit \$160, an order came in from the federal government to sell \$4 million of gold. While Gould and Fisk quietly slipped out of the exchange, panic ensued, as detailed by Chancellor: "The rapid fluctuations bankrupted thousands of margin holders, mobs formed in Broad Street and outside Gould's brokerage